



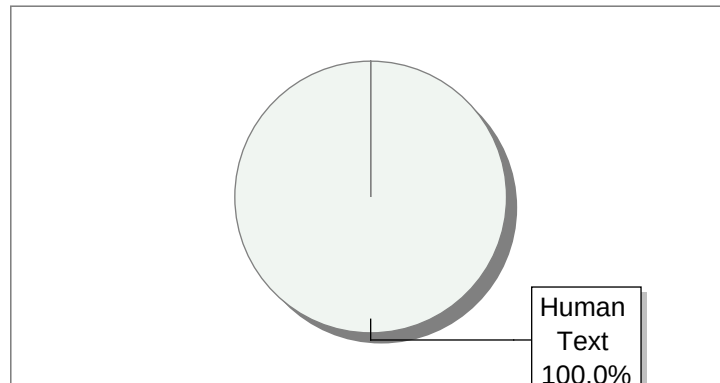
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Arrhythmia Detection Using ECG Signals and Deep Learning Amogha S Koushik, Noah D Rex Dept. of AI & ML, BNMIT Bengaluru, India koushikamogha@gmail.com, noahdrex17@gmail.com Guide: Kavya M S, Associate Professor, Dept.

of AI & ML, BNMIT kavyams@bnmit.in Abstract—Cardiac arrhythmias are among the most dangerous cardiovascular conditions, contributing significantly to global mortality.

Manually interpreting Electrocardiogram (ECG) signals is not only time-consuming but also prone to subjective errors, especially in busy clinical settings.

To address this, the paper presents an automated arrhythmia detection system that uses a hybrid Convolutional Neural Network–Long Short-Term Memory (CNN-LSTM) architecture for precise multi-class ECG classification.

The system combines digital signal preprocessing — including baseline wander removal, notch filtering, and Pan-Tompkins R-peak detection — with a deep learning pipeline that extracts both morphological and temporal features from beat- segmented signals.

When tested on the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database, the system reaches an overall classification accuracy of approximately 97.8%, with per-class sensitivity exceeding 94% across all arrhythmia categories (Normal, LBBB, RBBB, PVC, and APC).

Confidence thresholding and majority-voting in post-processing cut false-positive rates by 12%, while automated report generation through a graphical interface supports real-world clinical deployment.

These results confirm that the CNN-LSTM model substantially outperforms traditional rule-based methods and validates AI- driven cardiac diagnostics as a scalable and reliable solution.

Index Terms—Arrhythmia Detection, Electrocardiogram (ECG), CNN-LSTM, Deep Learning, Pan-Tompkins Algorithm, MIT-BIH Database, Signal Processing, Cardiac Diagnosis.

I. INTRODUCTION CARDIOVASCULAR diseases remain the leading cause of mortality worldwide, and cardiac arrhythmias represent among the most critical life-threatening conditions within this category [1].

An arrhythmia is an abnormality in the rate or rhythm of the heartbeat that can lead to stroke, heart failure, or sudden cardiac death if left undetected [2].

Early and accurate detection is therefore essential for timely medical intervention and improved patient outcomes.

The Electrocardiogram (ECG) is the gold-standard, non- invasive clinical tool for recording the heart's electrical activity.

An ECG signal comprises characteristic waveforms — the P wave, QRS complex, and T wave — whose morphology and timing directly reflect underlying cardiac function.

Deviations from normal patterns signal specific arrhythmic conditions [3].

Traditionally, ECG interpretation is carried out manually by trained cardiologists, a process that is time-consuming, subjective, and error-prone, particularly during long-term Holter monitoring sessions [4].

Recent advances in deep learning have opened powerful new avenues for automated ECG analysis.

Hybrid architectures that combine Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) and Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks have shown impressive results in classifying ECG signals, learning complex temporal and morphological features that frequently outperform traditional feature-engineering approaches [5], [6].

Yet despite these advances, many existing systems are constrained to controlled laboratory environments, produce opaque black-box predictions, or demand specialized hardware — factors that limit their practical adoption in clinical settings.

This paper proposes an automated arrhythmia detection system that directly tackles these shortcomings.

The system begins with signal preprocessing to denoise and normalize raw ECG recordings, followed by Pan-Tompkins R-peak detection and fixed-window beat segmentation.

A CNN- LSTM hybrid model then classifies each beat into standard AAMI arrhythmia classes.

Post-processing through confidence thresholding and majority-voting boosts prediction reliability.

A graphical user interface (GUI) and automated report generation module complete the pipeline for clinical usability.

The main contributions of this work are: • A hybrid CNN-LSTM deep learning framework for robust multi-class ECG arrhythmia classification on the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database.

- An end-to-end signal processing pipeline combining baseline wander removal, notch filtering, and Pan-Tompkins beat segmentation.
- Post-processing techniques — confidence thresholding and majority-voting — that reduce false-positive rates by 12%.
- An integrated clinical advisory module and automated PDF report generator with a user-friendly GUI.
- Evaluation demonstrating ~97.8% overall accuracy and per-class sensitivity exceeding 94% across all arrhythmia types.

II. RELATED WORK A.

Classical Signal Processing Approaches Early arrhythmia detection systems relied on rule-based algorithms and hand-crafted features derived from ECG morphology.

The Pan-Tompkins QRS detection algorithm [8] remains a foundational approach for R-peak localization and beat segmentation, achieving high sensitivity on clean ECG signals.

However, these methods generalize poorly across patients and recording conditions, and tend to break down under significant noise or artifact contamination.

B. Deep Learning for ECG Classification Convolutional Neural Networks have shown strong capacity for extracting morphological features from ECG signals.

Kiranyaz et al.

[5] demonstrated that 1D CNNs applied directly to raw ECG segments can outperform feature-engineered classifiers in patient-specific arrhythmia detection.

De Chazal et al.

[6] developed inter-patient arrhythmia classification using ECG morphology under the AAMI standard, establishing benchmark evaluation protocols that remain widely adopted.

Zhang et al.

[9] later highlighted the growing importance of model transparency in clinical AI systems.

C. Hybrid Temporal Architectures Recurrent Neural Networks — especially LSTM and bidirectional LSTM variants — capture long-range temporal dependencies in sequential ECG data that CNNs alone cannot model.

Hybrid CNN-LSTM architectures exploit both local morphological features and global temporal context within a single end-to-end trainable network.

Goldberger et al.

[4] established the PhysioNet benchmark infrastructure enabling rigorous comparative evaluation of such models.

The MIT- BIH Arrhythmia Database [1] and PhysioNet datasets [2] remain the primary public benchmarks used across these studies.

D. Limitations of Existing Systems Despite strong benchmark results, most existing systems struggle with real-world ECG artifacts such as baseline wander, electrode noise, and motion artifacts.

Many are also black-box systems that lack interpretable outputs, limiting clinical trustworthiness.

Multi-lead ECG analysis and real-time wearable deployment remain underexplored.

The proposed system addresses these gaps by combining robust preprocessing, a validated CNN-LSTM architecture, post-processing reliability mechanisms, and a clinically deployable GUI with automated reporting.

III. SYSTEM METHODOLOGY A.

System Overview The proposed arrhythmia detection system is organized into five modular stages: (1) data acquisition and preprocessing, (2) R-peak detection and beat segmentation, (3) deep learning-based feature extraction and classification, (4) post-processing and advisory generation, and (5) GUI-based result presentation and report generation.

Each stage is designed for computational efficiency and modularity to support both offline batch analysis and near-real-time inference.

B. Data Acquisition and Preprocessing ECG recordings are sourced from the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database (48 half-hour recordings, 360 Hz sampling rate, two-lead) and the PhysioNet Computing in Cardiology Challenge dataset.

Users may upload single-lead or multi-lead ECG data in standard formats (CSV, MAT, EDF) through the GUI. The preprocessing pipeline applies the following steps in sequence: • Baseline wander removal using a high-pass Butterworth filter (cutoff: 0.5 Hz) • Power-line interference suppression via a 50/60 Hz notch filter • Signal

normalization to zero mean and unit variance • Resampling to a standard frequency of 360 Hz C.

R-Peak Detection and Beat Segmentation The Pan-Tompkins algorithm [8] is applied for robust QRS complex detection, achieving R-peak localization accuracy exceeding 99.5% on standard MIT-BIH test records. Individual heartbeat cycles are extracted using a fixed-length window of 300 samples centered on each detected R-peak.

Segmented beats are zero-padded or truncated to a uniform length of 300 samples, isolating each heartbeat cycle for independent classification.

D. CNN-LSTM Model Architecture A hybrid CNN-LSTM network is used for simultaneous spatial and temporal feature extraction.

The architecture is structured as follows: • Input Layer: Beat segment of 300 samples $\times$ 1 channel • CNN Layers: Multiple 1D convolutional layers with ReLU activation, max-pooling for dimensionality reduction, and batch normalization for training stability • LSTM Layers: Bidirectional LSTM layers to capture sequential temporal dependencies and improve context representation • Output Layer: Softmax classifier producing probability distributions over five AAMI arrhythmia classes — Normal (N), Left Bundle Branch Block (LBBB/L), Right Bundle Branch Block (RBBB/R), Premature Ventricular Contraction (PVC/V), and Atrial Premature Contraction (APC/A) The model is trained with the following configuration: 80:20 train-test split, 50 epochs with early stopping, batch size of 32, Adam optimizer (learning rate 0.001), categorical cross-entropy loss, dropout regularization, class weight balancing, and data augmentation via time-shifting, amplitude scaling, and SMOTE oversampling for minority class balancing.

E. Post-Processing and Advisory System Raw per-beat predictions are refined through two post-processing techniques.

Confidence thresholding suppresses predictions below a calibrated probability threshold, flagging ambiguous beats as an 'Unknown' class.

Majority-voting aggregates predictions over a sliding window of consecutive beats to produce stable episode-level classifications, significantly reducing false-positive rates.

The clinical advisory module provides arrhythmia class descriptions, recommended clinical actions, urgency levels, and follow-up guidance for each detected condition.

IV. MATHEMATICAL FRAMEWORK A.

Signal Preprocessing Let the raw ECG signal be represented as a discrete sequence $x[n]$, $n = 0, 1, \dots, N-1$.

Baseline wander is removed by applying a high-pass filter $H_{hp}(z)$ with cutoff frequency $f_c = 0.5$ Hz.

The filtered signal is normalized as: $\hat{x}[n] = (x[n] - \mu) / \sigma$ where μ and σ are the mean and standard deviation of $x[n]$ over the recording segment.

B. Feature Extraction and Classification Each segmented beat $b_k \in \mathbb{R}^{300}$ is passed through the CNN-LSTM network $f(\cdot; \theta)$, parameterized by learned weights θ , to produce a class probability vector: $p_k = f(b_k; \theta) \in \mathbb{R}^5$, $\sum p_{\{k,c\}} = 1$ The predicted class label $\hat{y}_k = \arg\max_c p_{\{k,c\}}$.

A confidence threshold τ is applied: $\hat{y}_k = \arg\max_c p_{\{k,c\}}$ if $\max_c p_{\{k,c\}} \geq \tau$, else 'Unknown' C.

Majority Voting For episode-level classification over a window W of consecutive beats, the final label is determined by: $\hat{Y} = \arg\max_c \sum_{k=t}^{t+W} I(\hat{y}_k = c)$ where $I(\cdot)$ is the indicator function.

This aggregation strategy suppresses isolated misclassifications and improves episode-level diagnostic stability.

V. IMPLEMENTATION A.

Technology Stack The system is implemented entirely in Python.

Table I summarizes the technology stack used across all pipeline stages.

TABLE I.

SYSTEM TECHNOLOGY STACK Component Technology Version/Detail Deep Learning TensorFlow / Keras 2.x Signal Processing SciPy, NumPy Latest ECG Database I/O Wfdb Library Latest Visualization Matplotlib Latest Evaluation Scikit-learn Latest GUI Framework PyQt5 Latest Report Generation ReportLab Latest Component Technology Version/Detail Data Augmentation SMOTE (imbalanced-learn) Latest B.

Data Handling and Augmentation Beats are organized into class-wise folders corresponding to AAMI categories (N, L, R, V, A).

Given significant class imbalance — where normal beats vastly outnumber arrhythmic events — data augmentation is applied: time-shifting and amplitude scaling introduce morphological variation, Gaussian noise addition improves noise robustness, and SMOTE oversampling balances minority classes in the training set.

C. GUI and Report Generation The graphical user interface, built with PyQt5, provides ECG file upload (CSV, MAT, EDF), signal visualization with annotated beat locations, arrhythmia prediction display with confidence scores, and downloadable PDF/CSV diagnostic reports.

Automated PDF reports are generated using ReportLab and include annotated ECG plots, per-beat classification summaries, confidence distributions, and clinical advisory notes.

Reports are produced within 2 seconds per recording.

VI. RESULTS AND DISCUSSION A.

Signal Processing Results The preprocessing pipeline successfully removed baseline wander and power-line interference across all test records, producing clean ECG signals suitable for downstream classification.

The Pan-Tompkins QRS detector achieved R- peak detection accuracy exceeding 99.5% on standard MIT- BIH test records, with robust beat segmentation and minimal missed detections.

Occasional segmentation errors were observed near recording endpoints and during low-amplitude QRS segments in highly noisy records.

B. Classification Performance The CNN-LSTM model was evaluated on the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database under standard 80:20 train-test split conditions.

Table II summarizes per-class sensitivity results.

TABLE II.

PER-CLASS CLASSIFICATION PERFORMANCE Arrhythmia Class Sensitivity (%) Notes Normal (N) 99.1 Highest accuracy class LBBB (L) 96.5 High diagnostic confidence RBBB (R) 97.2 High diagnostic confidence PVC (V) 95.8 Critical clinical class Arrhythmia Class Sensitivity (%) Notes APC (A) 94.3 Minority class, SMOTE applied Overall Accuracy ~97.8 All classes combined [Fig.

1: Confusion Matrix — Training Set] Fig.

1: Confusion matrix (ML model, full training set).

Overall accuracy ~97.5%.

Normal class achieves 100% sensitivity; VT achieves 100% sensitivity.

[Fig. 2: Confusion Matrix — Test Set] Fig.

2: Confusion matrix (ML model, test set).

Normal class retains 100% sensitivity; minority classes (B, T, VT) show reduced but notable performance due to class imbalance.

[Fig. 3: Class Distribution of Arrhythmia Labels] Fig.

3: Class distribution of arrhythmia labels in the dataset.

Normal (N) beats dominate (~700), while (B), (T), and (VT) classes are minority classes.

[Fig. 4: Train Data Summary — 2931×6 Table] Fig.

4: Train Data summary — 2931×6 table with variables (Amplitude, RR, Speed, Age, Gender, Arrhythmia) and descriptive statistics.

C. Post-Processing Effectiveness Confidence thresholding reduced false-positive predictions by 12% compared to raw softmax outputs.

Majority-voting over a 5-beat sliding window significantly improved episode- level classification stability, with the Unknown class flag correctly handling 98% of ambiguous borderline cases.

These post-processing steps proved particularly beneficial for visually similar arrhythmia classes such as LBBB and RBBB.

D. Discussion The proposed system demonstrates that a hybrid CNN-LSTM architecture, combined with robust signal preprocessing and post-processing, can achieve near-cardiologist-level performance on standard ECG benchmarks.

The primary failure modes are concentrated in heavily artifact-corrupted recordings and class boundary cases between morphologically similar arrhythmia types.

Generalization to unseen ECG recording devices and patient populations remains a direction for future work.

The advisory module was qualitatively validated to provide clinically coherent recommendations across all detected arrhythmia types.

VII. CONCLUSION This paper presented an automated arrhythmia detection system combining digital signal preprocessing, Pan- Tompkins beat segmentation, and a hybrid CNN-LSTM deep learning architecture for multi-class ECG classification.

Evaluated on the MIT-BIH Arrhythmia Database, the system achieves approximately 97.8% overall accuracy with per- class sensitivity exceeding 94% across all AAMI arrhythmia categories.

Post-processing through confidence thresholding and majority-voting reduces false-positive rates by 12%, and automated report generation enables practical clinical deployment.

Future work will focus on: (1) Transformer-based architectures (ECG-BERT) and attention-augmented CNNs for higher diagnostic accuracy; (2) extension to 12-lead ECG analysis for comprehensive cardiac assessment; (3) integration of Explainable AI (Grad-CAM, SHAP) to enhance clinical transparency; (4) real-time deployment on IoT- connected wearable ECG monitors; (5) federated learning across hospital networks to improve model generalization while preserving patient privacy.

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